

Parallel One

Curate the Environment

Average leaders adapt to the environment. Strong leaders redesign it.

Leadership Model: CURATE

Put It into Play

Reflection Questions

Make time to reflect before you lead forward.

1. Where is my team experiencing unnecessary friction?

2. What conditions are helping people succeed, and what conditions are making success more difficult?

3. Am I delegating authority or simply assigning work?

Team Conversation Prompts

Use these questions to spark meaningful conversations with your team.

1. Do we understand what success looks like and why our work matters?

2. What unnecessary complexity have we accepted as normal?

3. Are we being asked to do too many competing things, and what can wait?

4. What is working well in our environment, and what should we redesign or stop doing?

Manager Conversation Prompts

Use these questions during your next one-on-one or performance discussion.

1. Where could I make expectations, priorities, or decision authority clearer for my team?

2. What barriers do you see that I could remove to make success more likely?

3. How can I encourage greater ownership while holding people accountable for outcomes?

Take Action

Which one or two of these actions would benefit my team and our performance most?

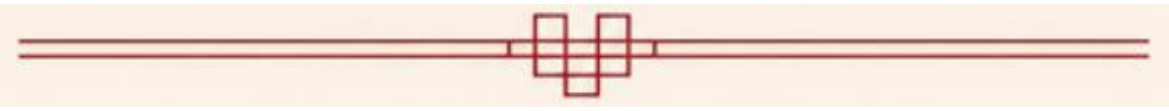
1. I will define success and explain how our work contributes to the organization's goals.

2. I will listen to my team and simplify one source of unnecessary complexity.

3. I will clarify tradeoffs and reduce competing demands on the team.

4. I will delegate authority and clarify accountability for outcomes.

5. I will assess what is working and intentionally improve one condition affecting performance.



Parallel Two

Learn the Rules of the Game

Authority is documented. Influence is discovered.

Leadership Model: RULES

Put It into Play

Reflection Questions

Make time to reflect before you lead forward.

1. Do I understand the organization's strategy, priorities, and decision rights?

2. Where does actual practice differ from stated policy?

3. Where do I need stronger relationships to be effective here?

Team Conversation Prompts

Use these questions to spark meaningful conversations with your team.

1. What norms shape how things really get done on our team?

2. What does someone need to understand to be effective here that is not written down?

3. Who shapes decisions or provides trusted advice without formal authority?

4. What do our rewards, priorities, and tolerated behaviors reveal about what we value?

Manager Conversation Prompts

Use these questions during your next one-on-one or performance discussion.

1. What unwritten expectations should I better understand before challenging how work gets done?

2. Who could help me better understand the organization and build relationships across the network?

3. Where could I strengthen my credibility before asking for support?

Take Action

Which one or two of these actions would benefit my team and our performance most?

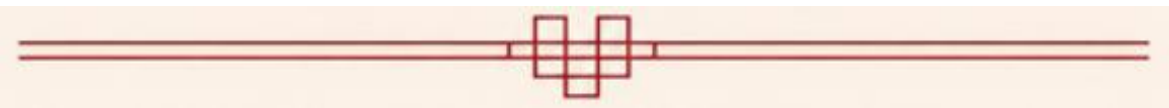
1. I will clarify the formal decision rights and performance expectations relevant to my role.

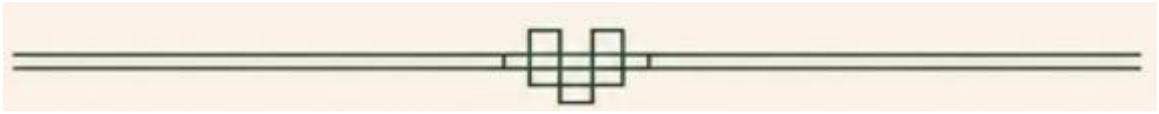
2. I will observe how work actually happens and identify unwritten expectations.

3. I will identify key influencers and build relationships across the organization.

4. I will compare what leaders say with what they reward, fund, and prioritize.

5. I will seek a mentor or experienced colleague and ask questions about how to be effective here.





Parallel Three

Ground Your Team in Ritual

Rituals do not eliminate flexibility. They enable it.

Leadership Model: RITUAL

Put It into Play

Reflection Questions

Make time to reflect before you lead forward.

1. Which consistent practices create confidence and trust for my team?

2. Does our calendar reflect our priorities?

3. Are our routines helping or limiting performance?

Team Conversation Prompts

Use these questions to spark meaningful conversations with your team.

1. Which successful habits should become standard practice?

2. Do our meetings have a clear purpose, the right people, and the right forum?

3. Does everyone understand our decisions, commitments, and who owns each action?

4. Which rituals should we preserve, adapt, redesign, or retire?

Manager Conversation Prompts

Use these questions during your next one-on-one or performance discussion.

1. Where could I make our meetings more intentional and respectful of people's time?

2. How could I clarify ownership and improve follow-through on commitments?

3. Where should I preserve consistency, and where does the team need more flexibility?

Take Action

Which one or two of these actions would benefit my team and our performance most?

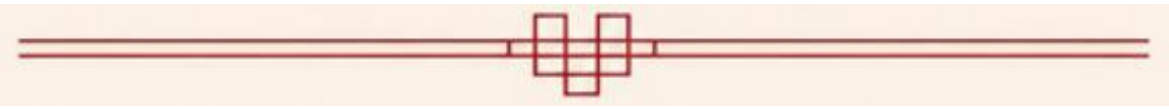
1. I will standardize one successful habit that helps the team perform well.

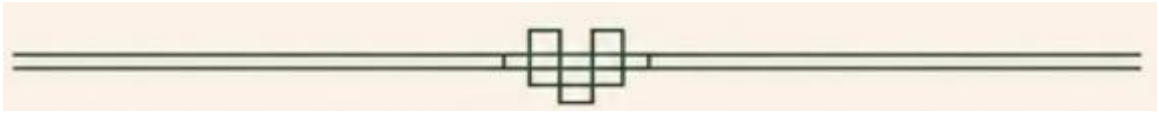
2. I will review one recurring meeting and align its purpose, participants, and format.

3. I will protect time for our priorities and eliminate one low-value activity.

4. I will confirm ownership, commitments, and measures of success after a team decision.

5. I will assess a team ritual and adapt or retire it if it no longer adds value.





Parallel Four

Harness the Power of Observation

Observation is disciplined intelligence gathering fueled by curiosity and attention to people, patterns, and change.

Leadership Model: OBSERVE

Put It into Play

Reflection Questions

Make time to reflect before you lead forward.

1. What assumptions am I making, and who might see the situation differently?

2. What distractions are limiting my awareness of people, patterns, and change?

3. Am I observing firsthand and validating what I think I see before responding?

Team Conversation Prompts

Use these questions to spark meaningful conversations with your team.

1. What patterns or changes are we noticing that deserve more attention?

2. What are people communicating without saying it, and what remains unsaid?

3. What additional context do we need, and who should we talk with?

4. What action do our observations require, and how will we verify its impact?

Manager Conversation Prompts

Use these questions during your next one-on-one or performance discussion.

1. Where might my assumptions be limiting what I notice or understand?

2. What signals or emerging issues do you see that I may be overlooking?

3. How could I improve my follow-through after identifying an issue or opportunity?

Take Action

Which one or two of these actions would benefit my team and our performance most?

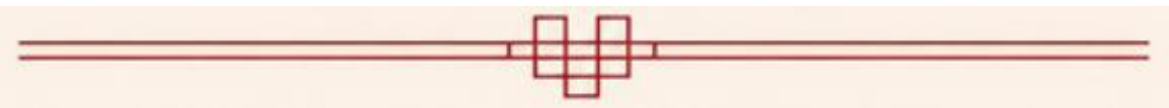
1. I will set aside distractions and observe a team situation firsthand.

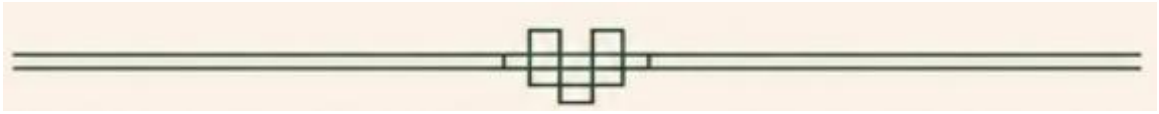
2. I will seek a different perspective and challenge one assumption I am making.

3. I will look for patterns and validate an observation through questions and additional context.

4. I will initiate a conversation or action to address an emerging issue early.

5. I will review the impact of my response and adjust my approach based on what I learn.





Parallel Five

Regulate Emotions

When leaders remain composed and reset, teams can focus, and execution is strengthened.

Leadership Model: RESET

Put It into Play

Reflection Questions

Make time to reflect before you lead forward.

1. What am I feeling, what triggered it, and how might others experience my emotions?

2. What do I know to be true, and what assumptions am I making?

3. Am I listening to understand or preparing to react?

Team Conversation Prompts

Use these questions to spark meaningful conversations with your team.

1. How do our emotional responses affect the team's focus and execution?

2. What helps us create space between a strong emotion and our response?

3. How can we be candid and respectful when a conversation is difficult?

4. How can we turn a frustrating situation into constructive action or learning?

Manager Conversation Prompts

Use these questions during your next one-on-one or performance discussion.

1. How do you see my emotions affecting my message and my team?

2. When could I slow down, seek more context, or ask a question before responding?

3. What could I do differently to coach, clarify, or collaborate in a difficult situation?

Take Action

Which one or two of these actions would benefit my team and our performance most?

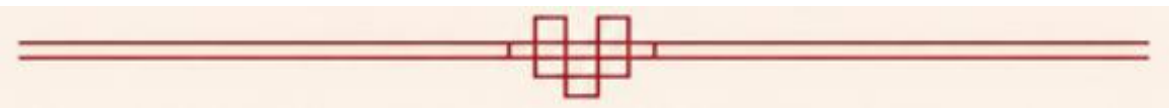
1. I will name my emotion and pause before responding to a triggering situation.

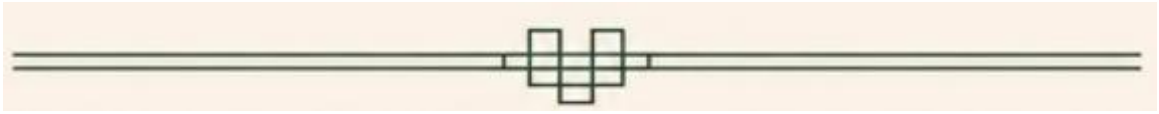
2. I will separate facts from assumptions and seek additional context.

3. I will listen carefully and identify the outcome I want before responding.

4. I will choose a candid, respectful response that serves the relationship and the situation.

5. I will channel emotion into coaching, clarification, or collaboration that moves the team forward.





Parallel Six

Master the Art of the Pivot

Persistence is staying committed to the goal. Discipline is knowing when changing the approach is what's required to achieve the goal.

Leadership Model: PIVOT

Put It into Play

Reflection Questions

Make time to reflect before you lead forward.

1. What new signals are customers, employees, or the market giving me?

2. What evidence challenges our current approach or suggests our assumptions have changed?

3. Am I staying committed to the goal while remaining open to changing the approach?

Team Conversation Prompts

Use these questions to spark meaningful conversations with your team.

1. What is changing around us, and what emerging risks or opportunities deserve attention?

2. What if our assumptions are wrong, and what other approaches could achieve our goal?

3. Have we preserved enough options and developed contingency plans?

4. Is it time to pivot, what should remain constant, and how will we communicate the change?

Manager Conversation Prompts

Use these questions during your next one-on-one or performance discussion.

1. Where might I be ignoring evidence because I want the original plan to succeed?

2. What alternatives or contingency plans should I develop before they become necessary?

3. What evidence would give you confidence that a change in approach is warranted?

Take Action

Which one or two of these actions would benefit my team and our performance most?

1. I will monitor changing signals and identify one emerging risk or opportunity.

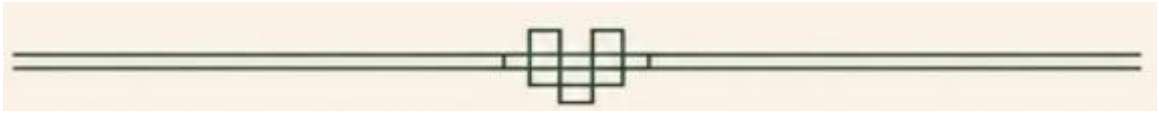
2. I will challenge a current assumption and develop alternative ways to achieve the goal.

3. I will seek evidence that both supports and challenges our current approach.

4. I will preserve alternatives and build a contingency plan where we risk becoming locked in.

5. I will act when the evidence supports a pivot and explain what is changing and what remains constant.





Parallel Seven

Balance Offense and Defense

Offense and defense are balancing forces, and leadership requires both.

Leadership Model: SHIFT

Put It into Play

Reflection Questions

Make time to reflect before you lead forward.

1. What opportunities are emerging, and what risks are increasing?

2. What are we ultimately trying to achieve, and what must we protect?

3. Is our current strategy still serving us as conditions and resources change?

Team Conversation Prompts

Use these questions to spark meaningful conversations with your team.

1. What has changed in our situation, and what game are we actually playing today?

2. Are our actions aligned with the outcome that matters most?

3. Do current conditions call for expansion and investment or consolidation and protection?

4. If we shift our approach, what remains the same and what does success look like now?

Manager Conversation Prompts

Use these questions during your next one-on-one or performance discussion.

1. What signals suggest I should reconsider the balance between growth and protection?

2. Where should I adjust resources or tactics while remaining committed to the mission?

3. How can I explain a strategic shift more clearly to my team?

Take Action

Which one or two of these actions would benefit my team and our performance most?

1. I will assess current conditions for emerging risks and new opportunities.

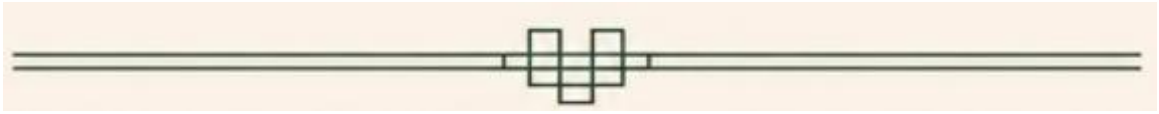
2. I will clarify the mission, the desired outcome, and what we must protect.

3. I will identify signals that indicate our current strategy may no longer fit.

4. I will adjust our approach to balance investment and growth with protection of resources.

5. I will explain the shift, reinforce what remains constant, and clarify what success looks like now.





Parallel Eight

Celebrate Every Win

Celebrating small wins doesn't lower standards. It reinforces the behaviors that drive long-term success.

Leadership Model: WIN

Put It into Play

Reflection Questions

Make time to reflect before you lead forward.

1. What positive behaviors or progress might I be overlooking?

2. Is my recognition specific about what someone did and why it mattered?

3. Who may be contributing without recognition?

Team Conversation Prompts

Use these questions to spark meaningful conversations with your team.

1. What examples of initiative, collaboration, or growth deserve recognition?

2. What specifically made a recent success meaningful for the team or organization?

3. Are we celebrating progress as well as results?

4. How can recognizing one another become a regular part of our culture?

Manager Conversation Prompts

Use these questions during your next one-on-one or performance discussion.

1. Where could I do a better job of noticing and recognizing progress early?

2. How could I make my appreciation more specific and connect contributions to impact?

3. Who might I be overlooking, and how can I encourage more peer recognition?

Take Action

Which one or two of these actions would benefit my team and our performance most?

1. I will notice and recognize a positive behavior that might otherwise go overlooked.

2. I will acknowledge progress early rather than waiting only for a final result.

3. I will describe specifically what someone did well and why it mattered.

4. I will connect a contribution to its impact on the team or organization.

5. I will encourage colleagues to recognize one another and make appreciation a habit.



Parallel Nine

Learn from Better Players

Learning requires discomfort—entering situations that force you to think and act differently.

Leadership Model: GROW

Put It into Play

Reflection Questions

Make time to reflect before you lead forward.

1. Where am I staying within my comfort zone, and what challenge have I been avoiding?

2. What feedback have I been reluctant to hear or apply?

3. Whose perspective or experience could broaden my thinking?

Team Conversation Prompts

Use these questions to spark meaningful conversations with your team.

1. What experiences would stretch our thinking beyond our current expertise?

2. What questions, habits, or approaches could we learn from more experienced leaders?

3. What feedback would help us work more effectively together?

4. Whose perspective are we missing, and who could challenge our assumptions?

Manager Conversation Prompts

Use these questions during your next one-on-one or performance discussion.

1. What am I missing, and where might I be creating friction?

2. What challenging assignment or unfamiliar experience would stretch my capabilities?

3. What would make me more effective, and how can I apply that feedback?

Take Action

Which one or two of these actions would benefit my team and our performance most?

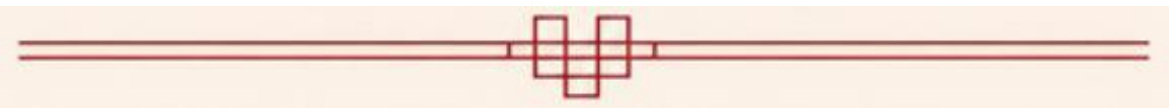
1. I will seek a challenging opportunity beyond my current expertise.

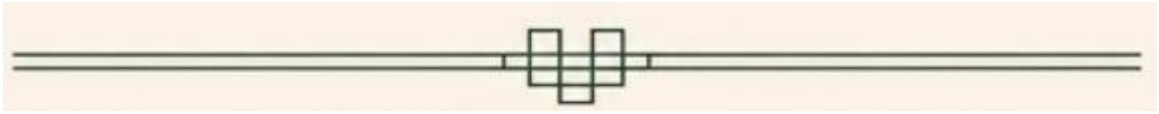
2. I will invite honest feedback and listen without defensiveness.

3. I will apply one piece of feedback to improve my effectiveness.

4. I will study an effective leader's habits, questions, or decisions and adapt what works.

5. I will seek perspectives beyond my discipline and build a connection that broadens my thinking.





Parallel Ten

Foster Connection

Connection is not a distraction from performance—it is the foundation of it.

Leadership Model: CONNECT

Put It into Play

Reflection Questions

Make time to reflect before you lead forward.

1. Am I creating intentional opportunities for people to connect?

2. Who may be isolated, unheard, or in need of encouragement?

3. Am I investing in relationships consistently and following through on commitments?

Team Conversation Prompts

Use these questions to spark meaningful conversations with your team.

1. What shared experiences would strengthen our relationships?

2. Do people feel comfortable sharing ideas and concerns, and are we listening to understand?

3. Whose voice is missing, and what barriers prevent participation or belonging?

4. What small actions would help us stay connected beyond immediate work?

Manager Conversation Prompts

Use these questions during your next one-on-one or performance discussion.

1. Where could I better understand people's strengths, motivations, and aspirations?

2. Who might I be overlooking, and how could I help them feel seen and included?

3. What relationship needs my attention, and what conversation should I initiate?

Take Action

Which one or two of these actions would benefit my team and our performance most?

1. I will create a shared experience that brings people together intentionally.

2. I will ask thoughtful questions and listen with curiosity to someone I have not connected with recently.

3. I will reach out to someone who may feel isolated and invite their participation.

4. I will learn more about a team member's strengths, aspirations, and what matters to them.

5. I will take the first step in a relationship that needs attention and follow through consistently.

